

Chapter 17 — Śraddhā-Traya Yoga

श्रद्धात्रयविभागयोगः : श्रद्धात्रयविभागयोगः

"The Three Kinds of Faith" · 28 verses · You are what you have faith in

Arjuna asks: "What about people who worship without strictly following scripture — what is their state?"

Kṛṣṇa's answer in Ch 17 is profound: **every human being has faith of some kind — śraddhā — and faith is not optional**. But it has three flavors, mirroring the three guṇas. Your food, your acts of sacrifice, your charity, your austerity — even your speech — all betray what kind of faith you actually live by. The chapter ends by introducing the sacred formula **Om Tat Sat** — the three-fold name of Brahman that sanctifies any action.

Essential verses of Chapter 17

BG 17.3 "A person is what their faith is"

सत्त्वानुरूपा सर्वस्य श्रद्धा भवति भारत ।

श्रद्धामयोऽयं पुरुषो यो यच्छ्रद्धः स एव सः ॥ १७.३ ॥

సత్త్వానురూపా సర్వస్య శ్రద్ధా భవతి భారత ।

శ్రద్ధామయోఽయం పురుషో యో యచ్ఛ్రద్ధః స ఏవ సః ॥ ౧౭.౩ ॥

sattvānurūpā sarvasya śraddhā bhavati bhārata |

śraddhā-mayo 'yaṁ puruṣo yo yac-chraddhaḥ sa eva saḥ ||

"The faith of each person is according to one's inner nature, O Bhārata.

A human being is made of faith — as is one's faith, so one is."

One of the most psychologically precise verses in Indian literature.

Word-by-Word — 17.3

IAST	सत्त्वानुरूपा	सर्वस्य	PRONUNCIATION	MEANING
sattva-anurūpā	सत्त्वानुरूपा	सर्वस्य	SAT-tvaa-nu-ROO-paa	according to one's inner nature (sattva = essence)
sarvasya	सर्वस्य	सर्वस्य	SAR-vas-ya	of everyone
śraddhā	श्रद्धा	श्रद्धा	shrad-DHAA	faith, trust, conviction
bhavati	भवति	भवति	BHA-va-ti	is, becomes
bhārata	भारत	भारत	BHAA-ra-ta	O Bhārata
śraddhā-mayaḥ	श्रद्धामयः	श्रद्धामयः	shrad-DHAA-ma-yah	made of faith / consisting of faith
ayam puruṣaḥ	अयम् पुरुषः	अयम् पुरुषः	A-yam PU-ru-shah	this person
yo yat-śraddhaḥ	यो यच्छ्रद्धः	यो यच्छ्रद्धः	yo yach-CHRAD-dhah	whoever has whatever faith
sa eva saḥ	स एव सः	स एव सः	sa E-va saḥ	that is verily what he is

Sāttvika charity — given without expectation

देशे काले च पात्रे च तद्दानं सात्त्विकं स्मृतम् ॥ १७.२० ॥

deśe kāle ca pātre ca tad dānam sāttvikam smṛtam ||

**"Charity that is given as a duty, with no expectation of return,
at the right place, time, and to a worthy recipient —
that charity is known as sāttvika."**

□ *Om Tat Sat* — the three-fold name of Brahman

ब्राह्मणास्तेन वेदाश्च यज्ञाश्च विहिताः पुरा ॥ १७.२३ ॥

బ్రాహ్మణాస్తేన వేదాశ్చ యజ్ఞాశ్చ విహితాః పురా || ౧౭.౨౩ ||

brāhmaṇās tena vedās ca yajñās ca vihitāḥ purā ||

"Om Tat Sat — this three-fold designation of Brahman has been declared. By this, the brāhmaṇas, the Vedas, and the sacrifices were ordained in ancient times."
These three syllables, prefixed to any action, transform it into a sacred offering.

□ Essential take-away of Chapter 17

Faith isn't optional — even atheism is a kind of faith. The question is only: **what is the texture of your faith?**

- **Sāttvika** faith reaches for the Divine, the pure, the eternal.
- **Rājāsika** faith reaches for power, recognition, immediate results.
- **Tāmasika** faith clings to fear, ignorance, harmful spirits, or self-destruction.

Examine your food, your giving, your daily rituals, your speech — they will tell you which faith you are actually living. **To upgrade your life, upgrade your faith.**

And prefix every sincere act with *Om Tat Sat* — it sanctifies the doing.